In Her Own Reflection

Contents

Little Explorers . . . 2
The Winner's Prize . . . 5
[English text unavailable] . . . 8
A Miraculous Journey . . . 8
Empty Tales . . . 12
[English text unavailable] . . . 14
Confession of Failure . . . 15
Passage to the Light . . . 17
Crossroads . . . 20
Back to Me . . . 22
[English text unavailable] . . . 22

Little Explorers

COL-312001

Little Explorers

Nautika: *panting*

Friele: Nautika, slow down. Wait for me.

Nautika: Friele, Aase, come on up! *pant* We're ... almost there!

Deep in the Woods

She scrambles over steep slopes and gnarled roots, her heavy steps leaving deep prints in the mud, yet her voice remains as light and cheerful as a breeze.

Nautika's Diary: I packed a lantern, canteen, and biscuits, along with Eanu Sven's notebook (though I already had every word practically memorized), and set off to track those miraculous prehistoric tree stump fossils.

Nautika's Diary: A congregation of silent woodland shadows embedded in the soil—witnesses to over 380 million years of history. If fossils could speak, I imagine they'd tell the most wondrous bedtime stories.

Nautika: Look, that ridge matches Eanu Sven's sketches perfectly! We must be getting close!

Nautika: These fossils look almost like palm trees or ferns, even. Totally different from almost any fossil I've ever seen.

Nautika: Look over there. Wouldn't you say they fit the description?

Nautika: Let's go! I have a feeling we're about to make a very amazing discovery!

Nautika's Diary: This marked my first true expedition. I was convinced if we ventured deep enough into the wilderness—kept going until the trees and mountains hugged us—then we would find it.

Nautika's Diary: The Mother Spirit whispered to me, and I followed in the promise of unnamed wonders.

Aase: They're just regular shadows, Nautika. Calm down.

Nautika: You guys wait here. I-I'm going to check ahead!

Friele: Nautika!

Nautika surges forward, sliding down the slope and, despite her stumbling, charging toward the faint promise of a miracle.

Friele: *sigh* She always does this.

Aase: Stubborn as a spring calf, that one.

Nautika: Aase! Friele! Come on—quick! I found ...

Her little hand waves frantically over the top of a distant hillside—perhaps, they think, she has found something after all.

They follow her up and then down the slope. In the biting cold, their hot breath unfurls behind them.

Nautika's Diary: My great-grandfather wrote in his journal as he traveled along the Mackenzie River that "most expeditions fail to yield what was originally sought."

Nautika's Diary: "The Mother Spirit pities Her children lost in the wilderness. She veils Her guidance in turmoil, reserving it until the end of their journey."

Friele: Nautika, what did you find?

Aase: That's not what I was expecting.

Nautika: She's still breathing, I think.

It's a reindeer calf mauled by some predator. It lies slumped under the roots of a tree.

Nautika reaches her hand out to feel for its breath. It's clear that it's near death.

Aase: She's not going to make it.

Friele: The Mother Spirit will guide her soon. She'll find peace.

She kneels and unscrews her canteen to offer the fading creature a final drink.

The calf convulses as it lifts its neck to gulp the water, its flickering eyes holding both agony and desperate hope.

Nautika: But she ... she doesn't want to die.

Nautika: We should take her back, don't you think?

Aase: Nautika, she probably won't survive the trip.

Nautika: I know.

As she looks down into its black-crystal eyes, she still feels a strength of spirit behind them.

She struggles to lift the calf. Her friends look on, weighing their decisions on whether to help her in her stubbornness.

Nautika: *panting*

Friele: Here, I'll help.

Even with Friele's help, the calf's weight is awkward. Earth sticks to their boots as they climb, making the burden all the heavier.

Nautika's Diary: That day, we failed to find any prehistoric forest fossils. But on the way back, I carried that dying calf in my arms.

Nautika's Diary: We walked quickly, afraid that we might feel the last twitches of her life with every step. Yet she held on—all the way until we found Áddjá, and together we stitched up the wounds on her belly.

Nautika's Diary: For the rest of the week, my body ached so much I could barely move. I felt like I was weighed down by a very massive weight—but the calf survived.

Nautika's Diary: I have to go back to the mountains, the forests, the glaciers ... I have to find what I failed to find the first time.

Nautika's Diary: They're ...

Bedroom - Night

Rolf: Nautika, what are you doing writing in the dark over there? Come on over into the light.

Nautika: Áddjá!

She snaps her diary shut. It can wait. Sharing with her áddjá comes first.

Nautika: Eanu Sven's notes can't be wrong—what if we missed something? Something huge?

She throws her arms wide to size up the problem, tracing the largest circle she can make.

Nautika: These fossils are different from regular ones, right? So, we need to start looking for them in a different way!

Nautika: It's just like the Mother Spirit said. When a river carves through land, the soil along its banks cradles different kinds of joy.

Nautika: Eanu Sven drew their shapes, but I was too busy looking down at the dirt to realize they were like real trees ...

Silently waiting among the forests, its crown frozen in time. Fallen leaves that once nourished those resting beneath it—millions of years ago.

Nautika: They're tall, really tall! About two—or maybe three meters? Because they were trees first, and THEN they became fossils!

Rolf: So next time, my little treasure should look up first, eh?

He sketches the fossil Nautika just described on a piece of scrap paper. Seasoned researchers like Rolf always have a knack for quick, precise drawings.

He adds a young explorer beneath the tree, cheering in triumph at having finally reached her goal.

Nautika: Wow! Haha! I'll use this to update Eanu Sven's journals, and complete the records.

Nautika: Huh?

She looks down to see the little reindeer calf, now recovered, nipping at her sleeve.

Nautika: Do you want to come with me? That tree where we found you might be exactly what we're looking for.

Nautika: Áddjá, why don't we go together this time? We can bring Aase, Friele—maybe even ask Koht too ...

She strokes the calf's head, already planning her next expedition—the emotions of the previous one lingering at the edge of her mind.

Nautika: Oh, right! And I wanted to sign us up for the reindeer race! I'm going to have to carve you a name tag.

Researcher: Rolf? I've got a letter here.

The little explorer's plans are interrupted.

Rolf: One moment.

Rolf: Nautika, why don't you mark the route on the map? You remember how.

Rolf: By the time I'm back, I expect a solid expedition plan. And don't forget to assign roles to your team—yes, that includes me.

Nautika: Got it!

The door opens, then softly shuts to keep the coming news at bay for now.

Rolf: What are their terms?

The messenger wears a troubled expression, crumpling the document in his hands as he whispers his report to the expedition leader.

Rolf: ...

Researcher: Rolf, do you still want to go? This isn't even ...

Rolf: Of course we're going.

Researcher: But it's not real research! There's nothing there worth dragging ourselves to the bottom of the world for.

Researcher: They're just paying us to be their puppets. We'll be on a leash until we dig up whatever they're after ...

Researcher: Which, let me remind you, almost certainly doesn't exist!

Rolf falls silent for a moment, his eyes glinting with calculations beneath his gray eyebrows.

Rolf: This isn't our first trip to Antarctica.

Researcher: We know that what they want isn't there!

Rolf: But remember those unique strata we glimpsed during our search?

Rolf: The last trip was just a brief stop—we never got a proper look.

Researcher: But ...

Rolf: Listen, between going and never going at all, which would you prefer?

The young researcher is speechless.

Rolf: Nautika never hesitates with that one.

Through the window, they see his granddaughter bent over her map, bobbing her head joyfully as she drafts her next great adventure.

Rolf: We're going to Antarctica. Let's make sure this opportunity isn't wasted.

Rolf: Make the preparations.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Winner's Prize

COL-312002

The Winner's Prize

Bedroom - Night

Nautika: Áddjá, are you going to go to that maze again? Are you going to break something off that big piece of rock this time?

Nautika: Oh! I'll rewrap the handles of your pickaxe and hammer with new ropes. Nice and tight! You're definitely going to need them!

The excitement over her grandfather's heading to Antarctica steals away all chance of sleep.

Day and night, she pores over the materials—her great-grandfather's journals, explorers' biographies, research papers, and specimen photos.

She closes her eyes, not to sleep, but to imagine herself crunching over those far-off glaciers, new questions popping up with every step.

Rolf: Alright, alright, ráhkis.

Rolf: We shouldn't worry about these things for now.

Nautika: But ...

Rolf: How about we blow out the candles?

For now, she swallows her curiosity, puffs her cheeks, and blows out the candle.

Nautika's Diary: This is it! My fifteenth birthday! Old enough to register for the race!

Nautika's Diary: And just in time too, because I have my own reindeer now! I even carved her a name tag.

Nautika's Diary: But there's something more important—Áddjá's leaving for Antarctica again.

Nautika's Diary: Oh, I wish he'd take me with him!

Nautika's Diary: If only I'd turned nineteen today instead.

Snowy Field

Villager I: Nautika! Tie that rope tighter! Don't lose yourself or your reindeer out there!

Villager II: Nautika, mu ráhkis, do be careful. We don't want to see you get hurt ...

Villager II: Even if you don't get first place, there'll still be a wreath waiting for you!

A wreath woven from white arctic flowers and bright bluebells nestled into green boughs—a prize for bravery.

There stands Nautika, the girl they watched grow up, gripping the reins for the first time at the starting line.

Both she and her reindeer seem a size smaller than the other competitors.

The crowd compensates with showers of cheers, encouragement, and affection.

Villager I: Go for it, Nautika! Let's see what your feisty little reindeer can do!

Villager II: Watch out for branches and go slow over the gravel, ráhkis!

Rolf: Deep breaths, Nautika.

Rolf: Close your eyes. The Mother Spirit will show you the way.

The starter raises both arms, whistle already pressed to his lips. One sharp breath will send the reindeer charging across the tundra.

Nautika grips the reins. Her heart is pounding.

Nautika: Áddjá, if I—

Nautika's Diary: If I'd found the fossil that day, if I'd shown you I was ready to be a real researcher, would you have decided to take me with you?

Nautika's Diary: And if I do win this race. If I prove that I have the courage and strength to do it ...

Nautika's Diary: Will you change your mind?

The whistle blows, cheers erupt, and a cloud of snow bursts up beneath the reindeer's hooves. The momentum lifts Nautika straight into the air.

The questions she wants to ask, her grandfather's concerned face—everything is left behind in the wind.

Nautika: Ah—aaahhh!

Nautika: T-Too fast!

Villager I: Oh no ...

Villager II: Nautika!

Their speed is incredible.

They overtake every reindeer, every competitor. Against the howling wind, Nautika feels the trembling in her legs as she steers her skis.

She looks up again. The little reindeer pulling her is all but swallowed up in the blinding glare of powdery snow. Pride and fear swell in her chest as she attempts to rein her in.

Nautika: If I can win this race ...

Nautika: H-Huh?!

The reindeer drives forward, her head low, losing all sense of direction and swinging off-course.

Nautika: No, no, no—wrong way!

Nautika: S-Slow down! No, stop!

She clutches the reins hard, trying to wrest back control, but it's too late.

Before she knows it, the reindeer has pulled her down the slope and into the snow-covered woods.

Branches whip at her, slicing her face with every stinging lash.

Nautika: *panting* Please stop—

Her vision shakes violently—until the cliff's edge, until her feet leave the ground—

Her feet slam to the ground once more, the snow thankfully absorbing the impact of her weight. Darkness begins to creep in.

Nautika: If I do win the race ...

Dusk is falling.

Villager II: Nautika ... please be safe.

The wreath's leaves are dulling fast in the fading light, its soft petals curling inward and wilting ominously.

Rolf: We're going back into the mountains.

Villager I: Get more people. Quick! Light's fading fast.

Friele: We're coming too!

Aase: Nautika's going to be alright ... I know she is.

Rolf: Mother Spirit ... please guide Nautika safely back to us.

His face is a mix of piety and fear.

The track this year was a mess of slush; many competitors slipped and fell over the course of the race.

But it was the youngest competitor who drew the most attention, with her lightning-fast start and quick disappearance into thin air.

Excitement turned to confusion, then slowly to panic, as it became clear their would-be winner had gone missing.

Deep in the Snowy Mountains

Snowfields. Slopes. Woods. Searchlights flare, but the swirling snow swallows their beams, and the howling of the wind shreds every shout.

Rolf: Nautika! ... Nautika!

Friele: Nautika, where are you? Nautika!!

Aase: Nautika!

The growing flurry buries any clues, yet hope clings stubbornly in their chests.

Nautika is nowhere to be found.

Time is ruthless and consuming. Nautika's life, and her people's hopes, flicker like a candle in the wind.

Rolf: No ... please, Nautika ...

Rolf: I can't ... not like this ...

Rolf: Mother Spirit, hear my prayer. Please bring Nautika back. Please ... bring my little treasure home.

[English text unavailable]

COL-312003

Five days on from her disappearance, just as the ship to Antarctica is about to set sail, unexpected news arrives.

Bedroom - Night

Villager I: Rolf! Rolf!

Every day since that day, he has prayed to his goddess, pleading for Her mercy.

Rolf: Mother Spirit, hear my prayer ...

Villager I: I-It's Nautika! She ... She's back!

Rolf: ...

Rolf: Nautika!

Nautika: ...

Nautika appears at the door, trembling, hollow-eyed. She's barefoot, her clothes stained with blood.

Rolf: Nautika ... my dear girl, are you alright?

Nautika: ...

Rolf: Shhh ... it's okay, you're safe now.

Nautika: Áddjá ...

Rolf: Blessed be the Mother Spirit in Her mercy ...

Rolf: She has brought Her child back to us ...

He envelops her in his arms. Just to feel the faint breath rising in her chest feels like a miracle.

His unwavering faith hears an answer.

Rolf: Nautika ...

Nautika: ...

Perhaps she had lingered too long at the edge of death to feel any joy in surviving.

Only her grandfather's voice, calling her name again and again, yanks her back from the dark's edge.

Nautika: ...!

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Miraculous Journey

COL-312004

A Miraculous Journey

Nautika's Diary: I'd never missed a single day before then, not since I first began writing in this diary. I wrote every detail of my life.

Nautika's Diary: But now, this habit scares me. I force myself to write down every detail ... only to black it all out later.

Nautika's Diary: I'm doubting everything now. I doubt myself. I doubt how I could have survived ... I even—

Nautika's Diary: Doubt the Mother Spirit.

Bedroom - Night

Nautika: *coughing*

Nautika: Mother Spirit, please protect me; please save me ...

Rolf: Nautika ...

The days bleeding in the cold have left her in a delirious state. She drifts in and out of consciousness, not knowing whether she's still out in the wilderness or safe in her bed. So, she continues to pray to the Mother Spirit.

But, then, her prayers break off, as if she has brushed against something deeper, something forbidden and dark.

Nautika: We fell ...

Nautika: It was dark and cold. I could feel my stomach growling ... I couldn't stand up ...

Nautika: I closed my eyes, hoping the Mother Spirit would come to me ... and then I—

Then comes the unbearable pain, creeping up from her legs, coiling around her gut, and clawing into her stomach.

Nautika's Diary: My stomach was eating at me from the inside. I'd never known true hunger before. It was painful—no, agonizing.

Nautika's Diary: I'd endured bitter cold and the ultimate exhaustion. I thought I could take on every challenge until that moment.

Nautika's Diary: Death's hand had brushed up against me, and I became the most selfish creature alive.

Rolf: And then what, mu ráhkis?

Nautika: I, I ...

Her eyes open wide as a violent spasm claws at her stomach. It's as if the triumph of survival, this wild joy of being alive, is too much for her to bear.

Nautika: *vomiting*

Rolf: It's alright, Nautika. It's all over now.

Rolf: No need to dwell on it any longer. Just rest.

He touches his granddaughter's pallid forehead, his brow furrowed in worry.

His hands are rough and warm, the calluses telling tales of years spent gripping an ice axe.

Nautika: Áddjá ... A-Are you back from Antarctica already?

Nautika: ... What's it like there? Has it changed?

Rolf: No, ráhkis, I haven't left yet.

The government ship is waiting for their leader to begin the search for treasures they would forge into power and authority.

A child just turned fifteen, still innocent and frail, shouldn't be worried with such things.

Rolf: But I believe this journey will be miraculous. We'll find that rock.

Nautika: That rock ...?

Rolf: Yes. This time, we have a clearer destination. Sit tight and wait for me, will you, Nautika?

Rolf: You've always wanted to go to Antarctica with me, haven't you? Well, one day, after I return, we'll make that trip together.

Nautika: No, Áddjá. I ... don't want that anymore ...

Rolf never could have imagined hearing such words from his granddaughter's lips.

Her passion for exploration has always burned even brighter than his own.

Rolf: ... What's the matter, ráhkis?

Nautika's Diary: I never thought I'd ever say something like that.

Nautika's Diary: Was it my brush with death that changed me? I had this gut feeling that Áddjá's Antarctic expedition wouldn't be what I imagined.

Nautika's Diary: It's not a pilgrimage to our spiritual homeland, nor some purely scientific mission to unravel geological mysteries.

Nautika's Diary: So, then, what is it?

Nautika: Áddjá, if we don't really set out for a destination ... then, do we still get what we're looking for?

Nautika: You said ... the Mother Spirit, out of kindness to Her people, gives us the harshest of tests. That's how we know we're on the right path ...

These words throw Rolf off balance.

Then, he lays a rough hand over her delicate one.

His granddaughter understands much more than he'd realized.

Rolf: The Mother Spirit, ráhkis, is generous, kind, and wise. She sees all the mess and pain of this world.

Rolf: And it is precisely the things that shake our hearts that we are meant to face.

Rolf: Nautika, I've never expected any journey to reveal all the answers or show me all that I could ever desire.

Rolf: The path to Her is long and arduous. It isn't always success as we imagined it that lies at the end of a journey. Just like with your first expedition, sometimes the reward is hard-learned wisdom for the next one.

Nautika: Áddjá ...

Rolf: You, my little treasure ... You have always been like the North Star to me.

Rolf: And that's why I must tell you this.

Rolf: I've always had a feeling ...

His gaze drifts to the window, as if already locking eyes with his faraway destination, his voice growing distant and cold.

Rolf: That this Antarctic expedition ...

Nautika's Diary: My passion for nature, my curiosity about the world, my pursuit of history—it all came from Áddjá.

Nautika's Diary: Long before I ever set out on my own journey, before I began my lifelong search, I prayed for his safe return—the man who walked the path I yearned to follow.

Nautika's Diary: And I was a part of his journey, too. A star to guide him home.

Port

The ship lets out a thunderous roar.

And with that, the Antarctic voyage begins.

Villager I: Rolf, everyone, buorre mátki! Come back safely!

Villager II: Mannet dearvan! May your journey be bathed in Her light!

Nautika: ...

Nautika: Mother Spirit ... I pray to you.

Nautika: Guide Áddjá. Let him walk the right path.

Her prayer is redoubled with conviction and concern.

News returns to them long before the ship does.

Some died on the journey—lost to storms or illness—and others at their destination. Their notices were brief, emotionless, and clinical, reporting the end of a life as if it were the results of a test.

They came in waves, but Nautika had not yet received any word of her grandfather.

She came to a dreadful conclusion as their team dwindled away. That this faceless, nameless specter reporting each teammate's death ... was none other than the expedition leader: her áddjá ...

Nautika's Diary: Antarctica is exactly as I imagined: cruel in its mystery. It never asks where its visitors are from. It doesn't care.

Nautika's Diary: Mother Spirit, maybe we never had your permission ... but we've never known how to stop, how to stifle our urge to explore.

Nautika's Diary: I beg for your mercy. I know that we're foolish and weak, drowning in a swamp of ignorance as we struggle toward the light. But I can't believe that we're just born to die ...

One bleak day, the ship returns.

Villager I: Rolf!

Villager II: Mother Spirit be with us ...

Rolf: ...

The villagers crowd around, peering behind Rolf in some strange hope that each reported death had been an error or a bad dream.

Nautika: Áddjá ...

But he stands there as the sole survivor, staggering toward the roiling mass of hopeless faces, the weight of every fallen companion on his shoulders.

No one holds him accountable for the lives lost—he has earned their trust a thousand times over—but there are burning questions in every set of eyes.

They had chosen this peril knowingly. The Mother Spirit lets each of Her children walk their own path to find meaning—even in death.

Nautika: Áddjá ...!

At last the weight of his journey seems to snap his last supports, and he sinks to his knees.

Rolf lifts his head, looking out at the crowd gathering around him ... or perhaps beyond.

His expression glows with something unearthly, his eyes both hollow and alive.

At last, he flashes them all an unhinged smile.

Rolf: Nautika!

Rolf: Everyone!

Rolf: I did it ... I finally found it!

Rolf: The stratum from the "Blank Era" ...!

Rolf: The relic of the outsiders, the true origin of life ...

The next second, he pushes himself upright, lifts his head, and raises one hand high. Light gathers in his palm as he clenches ... a stone.

Rolf: Something we've never witnessed ... that no one's ever laid eyes on before me. It's more than any of you could imagine ...

Nautika: It's a stone ...

A heavy silence falls, but Nautika steps forward, drawn to the stone despite the ravings of this man who only seems to resemble her grandfather.

Her gaze holds on it.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Empty Tales

COL-312005

Empty Tales

Nautika's Diary: Everyone else concluded that Áddjá never really returned from Antarctica, but there were times when I still saw him—moments where he became himself again.

Nautika's Diary: Only Friele and I were there to see it. In those times, Áddjá told us about everything he discovered on his journey.

Bedroom - Night

Rolf: It's a miracle, Nautika.

Rolf: It defies everything we know—doesn't match any known form, substance, element ... It's the missing puzzle piece.

Rolf: You see, Nautika? No trip is ever wasted. She tested us there ... and now, I have no doubt.

That was one of the last times she saw her grandfather—in any real sense. His expression was so clear.

She clutches tightly at his sleeve. Together, they crack open the stone to glimpse what lies within.

The old man removes his glasses, wiping tears away with childlike wonder.

Rolf: ...

Rolf: Nautika, what do you think?

Nautika: It's beautiful, Áddjá.

Rolf: Yes, more than anything I've ever seen ...

Rolf: Breathtaking. So very ... beyond this world.

Rolf: But it's just one piece of the puzzle, Nautika.

Rolf: ...

Rolf: I'll never be able to return there, mu ráhkis.

At these words, Nautika looks over her grandfather in astonishment.

This isn't some pessimistic fear. She's certain that in this moment he has foreseen his own end, much like the premonitions he had before leaving for Antarctica.

Nautika: No ... Áddjá, no, don't say that.

Nautika: You haven't cracked it yet. The journey has to have meant something; there's so much more to do ...

Rolf: You're right ...

Rolf: But that's not what I want, Nautika.

Rolf: What I want ... is to see with my own eyes what that time really looked like.

Rolf: Nautika, my little treasure, I pray that you see it one day. The Mother Spirit has always smiled upon you.

Nautika's Diary: I prayed for the Mother Spirit's grace to fall upon Áddjá; it seemed to me that despite all that had happened, he had nearly grasped the key to the mystery.

Nautika's Diary: After all, he'd been touched by the Mother Spirit's light, hadn't he? That's why we got to see that precious little stone.

Nautika's Diary: I had to believe it with all my heart ... but after that day, the Áddjá that I loved was gone, and I could only cling to the memory of this final night when his mind was clear.

Nautika's Diary: That's what kept me going as I pushed past every obstacle that stood in my way.

Rolf: Nautika ... Nautika!

Rolf: Ráhkis, we've all been fooled! Every one of us, for generations ...

Nautika: No, Áddjá ... that's not true.

Nautika: Look at this. See? You're the one who brought it back!

It was on that final night of lucidity that he solemnly threaded the stone onto a pendant and placed it around his granddaughter's neck.

Nautika: It's a relic from the "Blank Era," you said so yourself ...

Nautika: So, I'm going to Antarctica. I'll solve this mystery—for both of us!

Her grandfather gazes at the stone with wonder but no sense of recognition, his mental torment overwhelming the last light of wisdom in his eyes.

His skin clings to his bones, as if the soul that should have filled his flesh has already withdrawn and dissipated.

Then from those hollow eyes, tears begin to fall.

Rolf: No, Nautika, please ... my little treasure.

Rolf: Don't go.

Rolf: Everything there ... It was all ...

Nautika: Áddjá ...

Nautika's Diary: Even if I thought for a thousand years, I never would've imagined a day when Áddjá would abandon everything that mattered most to him.

Nautika's Diary: Even so, I will pursue the unknown no matter where it takes me.

Nautika's Diary: I'll search for the truth. And if I find it—if I bring it back—will it be enough to wake him?

Nautika's Diary: Everything there ... is not ...

Rolf: Just empty tales.

Nautika: ...

All she can do is sigh.

Nautika: No need to think about it anymore ... Just rest, Áddjá.

Those final words seem to pierce straight through her soul. In that instant, she is wrenched out of childhood forever.

Just as her grandfather had once done for her, she reaches out and touches his icy forehead.

Nautika: Rest now. That's right ... just rest. I'll take it from here.

Nautika: A second journey doesn't mean ...

Nautika: Doesn't mean the first one failed.

Nautika: It doesn't mean that at all ...

Antarctic Plain

Nautika: Well ...

The sharp polar winds steal heat. Steal strength. Steal lives. The lives of everyone she had ever known and loved. Now they threaten to steal her last flickers of hope.

Nautika: Friele ... Aase ...

Nautika: Koht ...

Nautika: I-It's not my fault ... It WASN'T my fault ...

Nautika: R-Right, Máhtu? It wasn't my fault, right?

Nautika: But ... they followed ME! *sniff* I was the one who planned this whole thing!

In these final moments, she argues with herself.

Nautika: But ... Yes, Áddjá found the stone, and I used it to lead them here ...

Nautika: But we all wanted this! We are the Mother Spirit's children! Who wouldn't want to witness a miracle? It was our life's dream!

Nautika: But they're gone ... hm ... Th-They died, terrified and lost ...

Nautika: Is that all their lives were worth?

Nautika: All of it ... W-Wasn't it all of our faults?

The snow rises over her knees. Each step is labored.

Nautika: No. Think about it, Nautika. From your very first expedition, all you've done is fail.

Nautika: After that, all hope fizzled out. All you have left is stupid guts.

The snow swallows her eyes. The world goes dark.

[English text unavailable]

COL-312006

Nautika: But ...

Nautika: I don't know how to stop ...

Nautika: I just ... *sniffle* ... never learned how to.

Tears stream.

Black tears. They trail down her cheeks, her neck, her body.

A searing pain follows. She knows this agony well.

Nautika: Aah ... *wailing*

Nautika: I have to keep going ... I have to ...

She reaches into the void ahead as thick, black sludge surges up to claim her. She is on the brink of annihilation, her soul like a dying candle in the night.

Inside the Gate

Nautika: It's ... a gate.

Nautika: It's my fault ... No, I can't stay here—

Nautika: Aah ...

Nautika: *sobbing*

Nautika: Mother Spirit ... Tell me I'm still on the right path.

Nautika: Hear my prayer!

Her voice fades. Then—light. It falls upon her at the last moment.

Her body is already gone. Soon, her soul will be too. All that remains is a wisp of consciousness—if it can even still be called "Nautika." The light shines around her.

And in its glow, she finally sees where she is.

A pulsing stomach filled with viscous black fluid. Countless souls have been digested here.

She is simply one more.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Confession of Failure

COL-312007

Confession of Failure

Nautika: ...

Nautika: Is this ... the end?

She seems to be nothing but consciousness now—if even that—yet she still clutches a pendant to her chest.

Nautika: Where did it all go wrong, Nautika?

Nautika: Your expeditions came to nothing.

Nautika: You ate your poor innocent reindeer.

Nautika: You ignored Áddjá's warnings and got your friends killed.

Nautika: Hah ... So, Nautika ... Where do you think you're going now?

Nearly dissolved into the sludge around her, she confesses her sins, though her repentance is far from pure.

Nautika: I don't know ...

Nautika: But ... I won't stay here.

Nautika: Even after all this ... I have to see for myself ...

Nautika: I have to find the answer ...

Nautika: I won't stop until I do.

A thought like that is indigestible to the darkness. It leaves her to wander, weak but persistent.

Nautika: I haven't written in my diary today.

Nautika: What's the point if I don't do it every day?

Her faint consciousness drifts blindly through the dark, searching for a diary that has already written its last day.

Nautika: Wh-Where is it?

Nautika: My diary ...

Then, a sound. A faint rustling, nearly drowned out by the stomach's contractions.

Nautika: Oh, there you are—

A thick, weathered diary is half-sunken in the black sludge, its pages promising to bear faithful witness to all that happened.

Nautika: W-What?

She crawls toward it, this fellow captive of the darkness ... only for the diary to suddenly burst into flames.

Nautika: No, no ... not you too!

???: Nautika ...

???: But Nautika ...

???: Do you actually believe that a diary could tell you the truth?

Nautika: W-What are you ...?

???: You've written and drawn and scribbled and revised every day of your life in that diary.

???: But still you let that chronicle of failures fool you.

???: Deep down, you know the truth that isn't written there.

Villager I: My goodness, Nautika! That's it! That's our girl!

Villager II: Mother Spirit bless you, little Nautika. Congratulations!

She bows her head as the floral wreath slips past her eyes and falls triumphantly over her chest.

A medal, roaring cheers, and thunderous applause—all for a child who, on her very first try, has claimed victory at the reindeer race.

Nautika: ...

Nautika: I-I won the race?

Rolf: Of course you did, ráhkis. No one's faster than you.

Rolf: I'm so proud of you.

Nautika: Áddjá ...

???: ...

Nautika: But I won the race ...

Spirit I: Of course you did.

Spirit I: And that wasn't the first time either. Remember?

Nautika: So I didn't ...

Spirit II: It was only a nightmare—a thing that never happened. Your reindeer was fine. You two won the race for the next four straight years.

Villager I: Nautika again! Back-to-back champion! She must be a reindeer-whisperer!

Villager II: You never cease to amaze us ...

Nautika: ...

Nautika: But ... Áddjá, and then me and my friends—we went to Antarctica together ...

Spirit I: Nautika, how could you not know your friends better than that?

Spirit II: Exactly. After all, you are all ... on the same page.

Nautika: Friele, Áddjá ...

Nautika: He's not himself anymore.

Years of mental frenzy have long silenced the once wise and fearless expedition leader.

Nautika: I-I want to go to Antarctica.

Nautika: He said that the Mother Spirit would guide us along the right path.

Nautika: If I don't reach the end of this path, then ... then I'll never know if it was the right thing to do.

Nautika: Goodbye, Friele. You three wait for me to come back!

Friele: Why are you doing this, Nautika?

Nautika: Friele, trust me ...

Aase: We're not doubting you, but you're talking about going to Antarctica alone—did it ever cross your mind that we could go together?

Koht: Eanu Rolf pulled off something incredible! We should finish the journey he started.

Nautika: You ... all believe in Áddjá?

Friele: We've never doubted him. Not for a moment.

Aase: We're not just going to sit around waiting for you to solve the mystery by yourself.

Friele: We're coming with you.

Nautika: R-Really?!

Nautika: Oh, Friele, Aase, Koht ... I'm so happy ...

They embrace, just as they did on their first adventure.

Even though they know their journey will be unlike any before.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Passage to the Light

COL-312008

Passage to the Light

Nautika: ... They died. All of them.

Nautika: They left me here alone.

Nautika: I ... hm ... I only made it this far because of them.

Spirit I: Tell us, why are their deaths so regrettable?

The spirit asks with confusion and an alien sort of honesty.

Nautika: Because they never reached the end. They got lost somewhere along the way. That wasn't the ending they wanted.

Nautika: It wasn't what I wanted either.

Spirit II: Poor Nautika. Your life's been so short. It's no wonder you're confused.

Nautika: ...

Spirit III: It's because our lives are short that we are never meant to walk the right path alone ...

In the deepest darkness, these souls begin to burn with their own light, searing through the vast, pulsing stomach.

Spirit I: You've received the revelation now—found new wisdom—you even have their guts.

Spirit II: Nautika, we've already come a long way from where we started.

Spirit III: From here on out ...

Spirit I: You need to get out of here. You're already the bravest of us all.

A radiant gate swings open—a distant passage ending in a bright light.

Nautika: Is this ... the way to the end?

Her vision is already fixed on the gate.

It seems so like the stories of the Mother Spirit's welcome: a light at the end of the path where all Her children will be led when they have nowhere left to turn.

Their eternal hope will be met, and they will see home again.

Nautika: Mother Spirit ...

Rolf: I've always had a feeling ...

Rolf: That this Antarctic expedition would finally show me Her glory.

Rolf: All the chaos of the world never shook me. You've proven I was right all along, mu ráhkis.

Rolf: With the Mother Spirit watching over us, there is no doubt we're on the right path.

Rolf: Nautika ...!

Rolf: Everything there ... It was all ...

Rolf: Just empty tales ...

Nautika: Áddjá ...

Nautika: But Áddjá's premonition never came true. He thought that he'd step through a glorious gate into the light.

The memory gives her pause.

Without a body, her drifting consciousness needs only to resolve itself to make a choice.

But this fleeting wisp—that might scatter at the slightest breath—still cannot let go of the illusion of home.

Nautika: Hm ... I need to think ...

Spirit I: Of course. The wise man always thinks before acting.

Spirit II: We'll be right here waiting for you ...

The other wisps drift away, while she wavers at the edge of decision.

She wanders through the mirage of her homeland, retracing the path of her first expedition—that ill-fated venture she remembers all too well.

She also remembers ...

Reindeer: ...

Nautika: Aah ...

The moment her voice escapes her lips, the reindeer calf drinking from the puddle stops, startled.

She locks her alert eyes with Nautika, then turns to leave.

Nautika: Wait—

Nautika: Wait!

The wisp of consciousness flutters after her.

Nautika: Wait for me ...!

The world surrounding her feels so real—as if she's a child again, bounding through spring meadows.

Nautika: *panting*

Reindeer: ...

Nautika: What's this?

A grave lies under a solemn tree. A breeze stirs, and the woven cloth tied to the branches brushes her face.

A handcrafted fabric. A token of mourning in her homeland's funerary rites.

It feels familiar.

Nautika: Whose grave is this? I can't remember ...

Nautika: ... Who's Dagny?

A name, carved in clumsy strokes, marks the mossy stone. Here lies a story unfinished, its last chapter written too soon.

Nautika: Whoever you are, rest peacefully.

Reindeer: ...

The wisp follows the calf through the landscapes of her home.

Cold air meets the warm earth, and the forest breathes out a morning mist.

The path ahead quickly becomes shrouded in a thick fog.

Spirit I: Nautika ... Nautika ...

Spirit II: Are you lost?

Luminous souls call her name from a distance.

Nautika: There has to be another way out ...

The calf stops by the riverbank. The two of them look out across the water, seeing only more fog beyond it.

Reindeer: ...

Nautika: Should we cross? The water looks deep ...

Spirit III: You've wandered too far, Nautika ...

The fathomless river blocks their way. The calf's hooves scuff against damp earth, hesitant.

Spirit I: You have to turn back before you get completely lost.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Crossroads

COL-312009

Crossroads

Nautika: You don't want to go through that gate either, do you?

Her flickering form draws closer to the calf, trying to ignore the tender, urging calls whispering at the edge of her mind.

Nautika: Seems we have the same idea.

Nautika: But taking a different path is never easy, is it? Sometimes we can't even find our bearings.

The fog devours the river whole, stealing all vision.

Nautika: And ... I think we've walked this path too long.

Nautika: We share a faith passed down through generations. A faith that we will whisper with our dying breath in hopes that She will guide us even in death.

Nautika: ... I know we're on the right path.

Her voice, too, begins to fade. It is now heard only by the calf.

Nautika: But even without Her guidance, we still would've made this journey.

Rolf: Nautika, what do you think?

Nautika: It's beautiful, Áddjá.

Rolf: Yes, more than anything I've ever seen ...

Rolf: Breathtaking. So very ... beyond this world.

Koht: Eanu Rolf pulled off something incredible! We should finish the journey he started.

Nautika: You ... all believe in Áddjá?

Friele: We've never doubted him. Not for a moment.

Aase: We're not just going to sit around waiting for you to solve the mystery by yourself.

Friele: We're coming with you.

Nautika: Because ... there isn't really a "right path"—only the path we choose for ourselves.

Nautika: And if it's just what we choose, then reaching the end might not be—

Spirit I: Nautika ... Don't let those thoughts poison your heart ...

Spirit II: Nautika, your pursuit must have meaning ...

She scans the water's surface. The fog thins, yet everything else remains blurred.

Reindeer: ...

Nautika: Meaning ...

Nautika: But I never once wondered what She'd give me once I reached the end.

Nautika: Money? Knowledge? The power to defy all odds? We never prayed for anything like that.

Nautika: When Áddjá sketched that first wild daisy in his notebook for me, that was all I needed to feel joy.

She looks to the gate, its radiant glow cutting through the mist, but she can't bring herself to reach for it.

Nautika: I want to fill up my diary, to fill up my sketchbook, to find that strange stone and trace it back to its stratum.

Nautika: I've always dreamed of climbing mountains and crossing seas—I need to know if they match the visions in my head.

Nautika: The mysteries, the prophecies in old tales, all the things that draw us into the unknown. Of course, I know that path is longer, maybe endless, even ...

Nautika: And I know how lonely it is to be the last one standing.

Nautika: But ... but!

If her voice carried any sound at all, it would be booming.

Spirit III: Nautika, you're lost ...

Spirit I: Have you lost all sense of the meaning you hold dear?

Spirit II: You've strayed from the right path ... from your kin ...

Nautika: No, it was never the "right path"! Only "our path"!

Nautika: Its end was never the "right answer"—only "our answer."

Nautika: But if that answer belongs to us ... then I'll see for myself what it is.

Nautika: Whatever it may be!

Over the river, the fog lifts.

Reindeer: ...!

The water's edge becomes clear, and the calf leaps to the bank without hesitation.

Nautika: ...!

She jumps too, in whatever sense a jump has in such a place, hoping to chase after it.

Nautika: Ah!

But she is no agile forest creature. She plummets into the river.

The cold stabs her instantly, the endless, churning water chafing and tearing at her, as if washing away all impurities.

Nautika: Ugh ... I can't—

Rolf: Nautika!

Rolf: Keep your arms moving. Don't stop! Don't let the cold take you!

Nautika: Ugh ... I'm ... I'm sinking ...

Rolf: Don't panic! Steady, ráhkis. Don't let your fear win.

It emerges in her memory. This is the same river from all those years ago.

Rolf: I'm right here with you, Nautika.

Rolf: Fight through the chill. You can do it. We'll have to live with its bite for quite some time.

Rolf: Nautika, this is what we chose.

Nautika: Aah ... ah ...!

She surfaces from the black water—the illusion of home, the radiant gate, the calling voices, they've all left her now.

Nautika: A-Am I ... out? Did I really make it out ...?

Reindeer: ...

The silent calf remains, her guide back into the depths of darkness.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Back to Me

COL-312010

Back to Me

Nautika: I'm still here ... I haven't vanished.

In the darkness, she tries to confirm her own existence. She is weak and faint, but thought after thought still forms in her mind.

Nautika: Hah, and at least you aren't completely alone anymore.

Reindeer: ...

Nautika: As long as you keep moving, you'll meet new people along the way. Like ...

Nautika: Like Vertin, Sonetto, and Ms. Radio.

The chains on her soul loosen, and fragments of scattered memories arise. At last, their names return to her.

Nautika: I hope they're safe now. I hope we meet again.

Nautika: I have to keep going ...

Reindeer: ...

"Keep going." A thing easier said than done. The black sludge creeps back over her mind.

She's still being digested.

Nautika: *panting*

Nautika: It isn't over yet ...

This might be the hardest part of her trek, with no clear direction and the last of her strength bleeding away.

The darkness swallows her wave after wave, dampening the thoughts flickering at the edge of being.

Yet, despite the terror of the moment, she doesn't pray.

Nautika: Áddjá ...

She wraps herself around that stone, the "miracle," heavier now than whatever is left of her.

[English text unavailable]

COL-312011

Nautika: Áddjá, white bones ...

Rolf: Look what you've found, ráhkis.

Four weathered bone fragments lie amid the wild tundra grass.

Rolf: Here's a vertebra, a rib, a small piece of leg bone ...

Nautika: Áddjá, what was it?

The lean scholar and his young grandchild stand together in a vast and silent expanse. He wipes his glasses with his sleeve, then moves closer to examine the bones.

Rolf: Most of them have weathered away ... It's hard to say, but judging by their size, it could be a reindeer.

Nautika: W-Why didn't the Mother Spirit protect it?

He smiles at her naive question.

Rolf: *chuckle* ... She doesn't work that way, ráhkis.

Rolf: This is the cycle of life. See?

Around the bones, where the flesh has rotted away, daisies now bloom. The wind has carried away the rest, scattering it across distant lands and seas.

Rolf: Nautika, this is the world's smallest miracle ... and its greatest.

Nautika: I know! It's from Tales of the Mother Spirit, the part that says ...

Nautika: In death we freed our tired, tattered flesh; And return life's power to nature's mesh. The rain and wind, our heralds, call us home; To Mother's arms—we rest, no more to roam.

Nautika: When I return to Her arms, I want to ask Her something.

Rolf: About what?

Nautika: I want to know how Her miracle works. How She keeps life turning in the endless cycle.

Rolf: That curiosity of yours is admirable.

Rolf: And what will you do once you know this information?

The child pauses. Her innocence has left her unprepared for such a question.

But then, a pure desire spills forth.

Nautika: Then ... I'll learn Her secret and understand another part of Her.

Nautika: In this reindeer's next life, I'll protect it.

She stares at the reindeer's bones and, in the boundlessness of her imagination, makes a small wish.

Rolf: Hahaha.

Rolf: Very well, Nautika.

Rolf: May the Mother Spirit guide you until your soul returns to Her embrace.

Nautika: Áddjá ...

Reindeer: ...

A long time passes before she realizes that she's no longer in a memory. Her grandfather's phantom hangs just out of reach.

She staggers toward him, still holding on to hope.

Nautika: Áddjá ... you knew, didn't you? You'd already seen the answer back then.

Rolf: ...

Nautika: That's why you didn't want me to face this final ...

Nautika: But that's the answer.

Nautika: No matter what, that's the answer.

Nautika: Even so, I will pursue the unknown no matter where it takes me.

Nautika: I know you understand, Áddjá.

Nautika: Because no one knows me like you do.

The phantom doesn't stir. Until, after what feels like an eternity, a smile of relief crests his lips.

He embraces her and whispers a single word.

Nautika: ...

And the phantom is gone.

Nautika: ... Let's go.

Reindeer: ...

Nautika: Will you stay with me till the end?

Nautika: ... Dagny?

She moves toward the exit, while true memories drift back to her like snow settling in her open palms.

Reindeer: ...

Nautika: Dagny ... Dagny.

Nautika: Aase and Áddjá said that you wouldn't last long. But I refused to believe it. I thought if I gave you a name, we could keep you.

Nautika: I carved a tag for you, whispered your name with every stroke—but by the time I tried to fasten it ... you were already gone.

Nautika: Then the very next day, Áddjá and I buried you beneath the sapling. Then I carved your name again.

Dagny remains still.

Nautika: Yes, Dagny, my little reindeer. I never ate you, and we never won any race.

Nautika: You followed the cycle—stayed with us for those last moments of your life, then left forever.

Nautika: Even so, there were so many nights when I thought of you, so many days when your name came to me.

Nautika: Oh, how I've missed you.

Nautika: You were my first adventure. My missing piece, the forest fossil I never found.

Nautika: The beginning of everything.

Reindeer: ...

She speaks the truth of this long-departed friend, finding that her words have sound once more.

The calf lingers, gazing into the distance. This is the final revelation.

Then, she bows her head and dissolves into the darkness.

Nautika: Goodbye ... Dagny.

She turns to the last path.

There, a pool blacker than darkness itself waits at the edge of the void.

Nautika: ...

This time, she doesn't hesitate. She wades in, slow and resolute.

She reaches the edge of the darkness and peers into the unfathomable water.

Nautika: I crossed coastlines and glaciers, escaped a maze, climbed snowy mountains ...

Nautika: I went beyond an illusion, refused a passage to the light, and walked free from false memories.

Nautika: I came here ... for an answer. That's all.

Nautika: The one true answer.

She shivers. Her voice chokes.

Nautika: The path we chose because of our longing, the destination we thought would fulfill our lives—

Nautika: What's at the end of this road?

She touches the darkness, waiting for its response.

Only silence. Only darkness.

Nothingness.

Nautika: ...

Nautika: Aah ...

Nautika: Ah ... ah ...

When reality confirms her premonition, all that remains is pure sorrow.

Nautika: So that's the answer ...

Tears stream.

Drop by drop, rippling in the pitch-black pool.

Nautika: Áddjá ...

Nautika: What we sought ...

Nautika: Then ... I'll learn Her secret and understand another part of Her.

Nautika: In this reindeer's next life, I'll protect it.

Nautika: When I learn this secret ... when I know the answer ...

Nautika: I'll understand a part of Her.

Images appear in the dark water.

Nautika: And now that I have ...

Nautika: Now I've reached the edge of nothingness; now I've seen that the answer is emptiness itself ...

Nautika: I became a part of it.

The reflection in the water is clearer now. She wipes the tears from her eyes.

Nautika: This isn't the end. Not anymore.

Nautika: Not my end.

Nautika: Not my final answer.

Nautika: I have to keep going—to find a new answer, a new meaning ... for who I am now and for who I'll one day be.

The reflection extends a wordless invitation to her.

Even as she wipes her last tears away, fresh ones fall.

Nautika: I'll keep moving forward ...

Nautika: Even so, I will pursue the unknown no matter where it takes me.

Nautika: Friele, Aase ...

Nautika: You don't need to wander anymore. I'll be here.

Tearfully, she smiles—just like the reflection in the water.

Nautika: Come back to me ...

Nautika: Come back into my arms.

She's determined.

Her consciousness breaks free from the eroding waves of darkness, flickering with a renewed, if faint, glow.

A light that comes from within.

Then, toward her reflection, she leaps into the depths of the pool.

THE END